

The People We Leave Behind

Project Overview

This project explores the bond between a grandchild and her grandmother, focusing on love, care, and the choices we make in life.

The story follows a girl as she interacts with her grandmother during a walk, evoking feelings of love, nostalgia, and human connection. Players make choices that shape the story's outcomes:

- Happy Ending: The girl reconnects with her grandmother, and they celebrate together.
- Reflective Ending: The girl continues on her own, and the grandmother reflects on letting go.

Concept Overview

- Many of us are nurtured and cared for by grandparents, who give time and love selflessly.
- As we grow up, life moves forward, and we face choices about balancing personal priorities with caring for our elders.
- This game-poem explores the tension between personal responsibilities and familial care.
- Through small, intimate scenes, players are invited to reflect on what it means to value someone who once devoted themselves to us.
- The experience is poetic and interactive, using gestures, choices, and sensory cues to create empathy and reflection.

Ideation

Early concepts explored various ideas before settling on the current narrative:

1. Lighting diyas during Diwali: Players would light diyas for everyone, symbolising sharing, care, and connection.
2. Animals and noise pollution: Highlighting how human activity affects animals in festival environments.
3. Fireworks and environmental impact: Showcasing the effects of firecrackers on plants and insects, possibly with a lighthearted tone.

After evaluation, the final focus became the walk with the grandmother, inspired by personal experiences during Diwali holidays.

Initial Development Process

1. Basic Story Layout

- Started with a rough outline: the girl walks, the grandmother walks, and they meet or separate depending on choices.
- Background images were used as placeholders to test scene flow.

2. Sprite Movement and Interaction

- Implemented walking animations for both the girl and grandmother.
- Developed distance-based interaction logic: grandmother slows down, stops, or moves alongside the girl depending on player actions.

3. Branching Storylines

- Player choices were introduced:
 - Continue walking → tension and reflective ending.
 - Go back to care for grandmother → leads to a happy ending.
- Placeholders and branching logic ensured smooth transitions between scenes.

Iterative Development

1. Scene Sequencing

- Added transitions for the girl walking forward/backwards, grandmother lagging, stopping, or merging paths.
- Managed text and scene persistence carefully to prevent leftover messages when returning to previous scenes.

2. Endings

- Happy Ending: Girl and grandmother meet, walk together, and celebrate with a fireworks animation.
- Reflective Ending: Girl continues alone, grandmother reflects on letting go, with a quiet final scene.

3. Animation Improvements

- Merged sprite animations for the girl and grandmother walking together.
- Added continuous firework animation loop for celebratory effect.
- Added ambient sounds such as footsteps, coughing, and breathing.
- Background music and fireworks enhanced emotional depth.
- Plan to replace pre-made sounds with original recordings for a more authentic feel.
- Added emotional text and small poetic lines to enhance the emotions

Challenges Faced

- Text sometimes displayed incorrectly when navigating backwards.
- Complex branching logic made sprite state management challenging.
- Synchronising girl and grandmother movement with speed variations and stopping conditions.
- Ensuring clickable areas triggered correct images and animations depending on path and ending.
- Coordinating breathing, coughing, and environmental sounds with animations.
- Crafting lines that evoke emotion naturally was difficult.

Next Steps & Future Work

1. Replace pre-made sounds with original recordings.
2. Refine poetic lines and dialogue for more impactful reflection.
3. Expand intermediate branches for replay value.
4. Further polish animations for natural movement.